



The Next Big Idea

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As with any path breaking technology, every now and then you get a promising rival that is touted as the predecessor's killer. It has happened with the iPhone, but we are yet to see a definitive iPhone killer. And now, Google is said to have another killer rival. Recently, we came across several blogs and news items that claimed Kosmix, a three-month old search tool, to be the next big thing in the web search domain. Some even going to the extent of calling it the harbinger of Google's doom. What is ironic, however, is that while the media has been busy building up the Kosmix bubble, its founders (two silicon valley based Indians) are going to great lengths to underplay their product, especially when it comes to drawing comparisons with Google.

Unlike a normal search engine that displays results which contain your search phrase, Kosmix generates a

dynamic results page on the fly, populated by content from other sources. These snippets of information are gathered from web sites such as Wikipedia, blogs, videos, photos, news and image results from Google. The idea is to give you a bird's eye view of a particular topic. Search engines such as Google help users find specific information in the form of web sites, research papers or flight schedules. Hence the founders have given their product the moniker of *explore engine* and not search engine. Kosmix's page title "The web organized for you" is perhaps an allusion to this concept. Sounds interesting, right?

We decided to give it a whirl for two reasons. One was the obvious curiosity about how it matches up to Google and the other to confirm reports from a New York Times article that Kosmix is best suited for certain specific uses. A quick random search will give you more than an inkling that this tool is not meant for serious research.

Kosmix

A search for one of our favourite bands "Porcupine Tree" proved to be quite futile as a guide, or even as a starting point. Agreed, the topic is still not serious enough, but it makes you wonder how the site will handle "quantum physics".

So, is it good for anything at all? Reports suggest that Kosmix does well in certain categories of searches such as travel, sports, health and electronics. For these categories, Kosmix is supposed to generate pages so specific and content rich that companies spending fortunes on developing such pages will squirm in their pants. A search on "Jaipur", had us mildly surprised. Apart from the normal and annoying results from Wikipedia and Google images, the web site managed to cull some interesting contextual content. The result page had a Google map of Jaipur, results from Hostelworld for cheap accommodation, travelogue videos from blinkx, and further down the page Trip Plans from Yahoo! Travel. Further down were interesting "how to" guides such as "How to Visit Jaipur" and "How to Buy Gems in Jaipur" from ehow.com. It would've been nice if the order of the results was different, but in the context of planning a trip, Kosmix can certainly be a good place to start. Was it useful to someone writing a college research paper on the city? Not at all. Go ahead and try it out, but certainly no one is expected to delete their bookmark for Google anytime soon.

Play in the cloud

Speaking of market disruptive technologies, something quite phenomenal is happening or rather could happen in the gaming world in the near future. OnLive, the revolutionary digital distribution technology, which was unveiled at the Game Developers Conference in San Francisco recently, could allow you to stream any game over a broadband connection to your computer, irrespective of your hardware. Essentially, this will turn any computer into a high-end gaming console.

With OnLive's mega servers that remotely process and render signals, theoretically any PC, Mac, TV or even a piddly netbook can become a receiving station for ultra high-end games. For you to be able to play on your large screen TV, OnLive will be offering a modem-like hardware device called the MicroConsole. It's most likely that the device will act as

a thin client between your display and internet connection. A built in web browser will provide functionality and the device will have USB inputs and HDMI output.

What's the catch? Obviously, for people living in this part of the world, it's broadband! OnLive can dish out 60 frames per second in Wii quality at a bandwidth of 1.5 Mbps. At a bandwidth of 5 Mbps it can do 720p! How is this done? No one really knows but has to do with some insane interactive video compression algorithms that have latency low enough to support



on-line multi-player setups. So you guessed it — there is going to be large scale community activity too. This will include standard leaderboards, rankings and level indicators apart from the ability to join live games at any point. An interesting concept debuted by OnLive was the creation of "brag-